

Module 2: Drama Vocabulary and Warm-Ups

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Kindergarten	Warm-Up: Wiggle Worms
UEN Standard	K.T.P.4: Use the body to communicate meaning through space, shape, energy, and gesture.
How it meets the standard	Students transform their bodies into active “wiggle worms,” then freeze on cue. Changing energy and shape helps them communicate an idea physically while practicing control of their bodies in shared space.

Grade 1	Warm-Up: Sound/Action Stories
UEN Standard	1.T.P.3: Observe, listen, and respond in character to other actors.
How it meets the standard	Students listen closely to a narrated story, echo lines, and respond with character actions. Their movements and sounds depend on the narrator and classmates, so the activity builds responsive acting and sustained participation in an imagined story.

Grade 2	Warm-Up: Pass and Pretend
UEN Standard	2.T.CR.5: Create character through physical movement, gesture, sound and/or speech and facial expression based on stories or through improvisation.
How it meets the standard	Students improvise by transforming a simple object into something new and showing its use through pantomime. Each choice requires imagination, purposeful gesture, and clear physical expression so classmates can understand the invented object or character action.

Grade 3	Warm-Up: Play Ball
UEN Standard	3.T.P.6: Use imagination to support artistic choices.
How it meets the standard	Students visualize the size, weight, and movement of several imaginary balls as they throw and catch them. They must make consistent physical choices so the audience can identify each ball, using imagination to make invisible objects believable.

Grade 4	Warm-Up: Character Voices
UEN Standard	4.T.P.5: Communicate meaning using the voice through volume, pitch, tone, rate, and clarity.
How it meets the standard	Students say an ordinary sentence as a selected character and adjust vocal qualities to communicate identity and feeling. Peers identify the clues they heard, helping performers recognize how volume, pitch, tone, rate, and clarity shape meaning.

Grade 5	Warm-Up: One Word at a Time
UEN Standard	5.T.P.2: Perform as a productive and responsible member of an acting ensemble in both rehearsal and performance situations.
How it meets the standard	Students build one sensible sentence or story together, adding only one word on each turn. Success depends on listening, accepting others' ideas, contributing responsibly, and keeping the shared creation moving as an ensemble.

Grade 6	Warm-Up: Stage Directions
UEN Standard	6.T.P.8: Identify and use appropriate vocabulary to describe kinds of stage spaces, stage directions, areas of the stage, and basic blocking techniques.
How it meets the standard	Students physically move to stage right, stage left, center stage, or the audience area as directions are called. The quick movement connects theatre vocabulary to the actor's viewpoint and gives students repeated practice with basic stage geography and blocking.

Child Development Reflection

Theorist selected: Jean Piaget

Piaget’s theory explains that children construct understanding through active interaction with the world. Many elementary students are in the **preoperational stage** (about ages 2–7) or the **concrete operational stage** (about ages 7–11). Preoperational children learn through symbolic play, imitation, language, and pretending, which makes process drama a natural way for them to represent people, objects, and events. Concrete operational children increasingly organize information logically when they can connect ideas to visible actions and real examples.

This relates closely to teaching theatre because drama turns abstract ideas into concrete experiences. Students can explore character, conflict, culture, and emotion by moving, speaking, creating images, and solving problems with classmates. I would give younger children clear modeling, sensory prompts, and short pretend-play structures. With older elementary students, I would add sequencing, rules, perspective taking, and reflection so they can explain why a dramatic choice worked. In both stages, the teacher should provide developmentally appropriate choices and allow students to learn by doing rather than relying only on verbal explanation.

Vocabulary Used in the Classroom Poster

CREATE	PERFORM	RESPOND	CONNECT
imagination	body	audience	ensemble
character	voice	observe	collaborate
setting	gesture	feedback	culture
plot	facial expression	criteria	experience
conflict	space	reflect	theme
dialogue	blocking	choice	story

Sources: Utah State Board of Education/UEN elementary drama standards (K–6); Claudia E. Cornett, *Creating Meaning Through Literature and the Arts*, “Energizers and Warm-Ups.”